

processor, faster than most consumer PCs at the time, the upcoming PS4's innards are more reminiscent of a PC than ever before. Based on the x86-64 architecture, the new PS4 will sport a custom AMD processor and graphics chip with a whopping 8 cores and 1.84 TFLOPS AMD next-generation Radeon graphics engine. It will also have 8GB of DDR5 RAM and built-in hard drive of unknown capacity. Optical media is still on Blu-ray, while USB ports will now support USB 3.0. Ethernet, Wi-Fi and Bluetooth support will also feature on the upcoming PS4, according to Sony's statement. Reminds you of a high-powered laptop, doesn't it?

The new DUALSHOCK controller largely remains the same but with a fresh new twist – it sports a touchpad strip at the top. A new highly sensitive six-axis sensor enables motion control on the DUALSHOCK 4 controller, with allegedly fine tuned analog sticks. The L2 and R2 triggers have received a minor facelift, while the Start and Select buttons have been booted out. There's also a new 3D depth-sensing camera (with PS4) to complement the Move motion controller better than ever. Hardware upgrades are part and parcel, and to be honest we were expecting some of these changes on the PlayStation 4 – anything less and it would be dud on arrival. However, what made us sit up and take notice were the following two revelations. First, the upcoming PS4 will showcase a new dimension of cloud gaming with Gaikai integration (Google it). Gamers will be able to jump into a game directly from the PlayStation Store, try it out, and purchase it instantly. Online friends won't just spectate and comment on their friend's game but can also jump in to aid if the situation calls for it – tackling a difficult boss, for example. Also, games will be backward compatible only through online streaming on PS4 – wonder how that will work out. What's more, all these features seem only a fraction of what Sony can enable on PS4 through Gaikai.

Second of these disruptions is the ability to play any PS4 title on a secondary screen. Any number of supported screens, making PS4 gaming an intimately mobile

affair. This can be through any device such as the PlayStation Vita (PS Vita), smartphones or tablets, Sony says. A key feature enabled by second screens is "Remote Play". So anyone who has a PS Vita will be able to seamlessly pull PS4 titles away from their TVs and play them on the Sony handheld's 5-inch display over Wi-Fi networks. This is a great move by Sony to ensure longevity for PS Vita, and absorbing it into a future ecosystem. Similarly, a "Playstation App" will be made available on Apple and Google's app stores to enable iPhones, iPads and Android devices into secondary screens to display additional game-related content for the PS4. This sounds very interesting indeed and an important step towards connected devices striving to deliver a comprehensive entertainment experience.

Hopping on to the Xbox bandwagon, things are still a bit sketchy. Don't get us wrong, news about the likely successor to Microsoft's Xbox 360 game console has been leaking for a few years now, but not until a few months ago (when Microsoft seemingly was busy checking off the few remaining things on the next big Xbox)



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has the magnitude of Xbox-related news shot up, signalling an impending launch of the console. All eyes are on Microsoft's Xbox team at Redmond, the company's headquarters, and what they'll unveil on May 21. But whatever little we do know, from speculation, here it is. It all starts with the name: what's it going to be called? Hacks wasted no time in referring to the successor of the Xbox 360 as Xbox 720 in all their rumor mongering. Later it was leaked that the Xbox project is codenamed Durango, and the name may stick. However, consensus has grown surrounding a



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leaked Microsoft flyer proclaiming its next game console as "Xbox Infinity", which definitely has a nice ring to it. While its name may not be of great concern to many eager customers, what the new Xbox packages inside it will most certainly be a topic of intense scrutiny. According to The Verge, the console is said to include an 8-core 64-bit APU running at 1.6GHz, alongside 8GB of DDR3 memory and a large HDD for storage. Apart from this, the next-gen Xbox is also speculated to have the exact same AMD graphics as the Sony PS4. This is significant, because it means that the future of console gaming won't be decided by specs alone. On the software front, the next Xbox console could run a flavour of Windows 8 to justify Microsoft's broader vision to maintain uniformity of interface across devices. Skype, Microsoft's multi-billion dollar acquisition, is also slated to be embedded deep within the next Xbox's USP. As far as the look and feel of the console goes, unlike Sony's PS4 event in February which didn't reveal the PS4 itself, Microsoft's ensuring that it gives everyone a good look at the next-gen Xbox console on its May 21 event. May be that will help reassure eager fans and steal a lead on the mysterious-looking PS4. A great example of Microsoft's innovation, its Kinect controller, will no doubt be unveiled in a refreshed avatar as well. While industry experts expect Kinect 2 to be smaller and thinner than the original Kinect, it's slated to feature a whole host of feature enhancements. Kinect 2's expected to improve depth and movement tracking, allowing up

